I did and they got no closer to realizing it than a studio front gate.

A few weeks before my departure for California in 1937, however, something happened that made Hollywood seem a little less remote from Des Moines. Our station had a popular Saturday night barn dance program featuring a terrific group of musicians called the Oklahoma Outlaws. Gene Autry had heard about the group and signed them to appear in one of his singing cowboy movies. The studios in those days were constantly looking for ways to broaden their audience, and the Oklahoma Outlaws had a big following in the Midwest.

That April when I arrived in Los Angeles for my annual ten-day reporting tour, a storm was socking Southern California with a ferocity that probably set back the Chamber of Commerce's promotional efforts at least a year or two. The streets were flooded, high winds were felling the city's towering palm trees like stalks of wheat, and the horizon was ugly and gray.

I decided to play hooky from the Cubs and took a trolley to Republic Studios so I could watch my friends in the Oklahoma Outlaws act out their new, if temporary role as motion picture players. I'd planned to leave for Catalina that evening, but high seas along the twenty-one-mile Catalina channel were forcing boats to turn back, seaplanes were grounded, and the Cubs' hotel on the island was cut off from the town of Avalon by mud slides.

So I checked into the Biltmore Hotel in downtown Los Angeles, which is where the Cubs stayed when they were playing exhibition games with their farm club, the Los Angeles Angels, and that evening I walked downstairs to the Biltmore Bowl, a nightclub on the lower level, to look up a fellow Iowan, Joy Hodges.

Joy, a singer who had once worked for WHO, had come to Los Angeles several years before with hopes of breaking into